

Michael Lopez

Data Strategist · Civic Tech & Social Impact

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Data strategist and operations leader. Six years building the Child Poverty Action Lab's data function from the ground up — the team, the Databricks platform, and the tools that turn public and administrative data into decisions across housing, public safety, maternal health, and benefits delivery.

EXPERIENCE

Child Poverty Action Lab · Dallas, TX · 2020 – Present

Director, Data Operations

Jan 2026 – Present

- Lead CPAL's data platform migration to Databricks (Unity Catalog, Workflows, Lakebase + Lakehouse on AWS, Git-tracked orchestration), systematizing 35–40 pipelines from file-based storage onto unified cloud infrastructure
- Manage a 6-person external data engineering team via vendor partnership executing the internal data roadmap, alongside one full-time data engineer reporting directly to me
- Built AI-enabled team workflows (Claude Code with custom skills and agents, prompt caching with the Anthropic API), accelerating how we develop pipelines, write documentation, review code, and communicate with stakeholders
- Develop internal tools that let non-data staff act on data without analyst intervention, including a parcel-level outreach tool with 20 active field-team users
- Maintain the eviction data workstream (~48,000 Dallas filings a year across four North Texas counties; daily feed to 12+ partners including the Dallas Eviction Advocacy Center, the Princeton Eviction Lab, and Dallas Health & Human Services)

Director, Data

May 2023 – Dec 2025

- Built CPAL's data function from the ground up; led hiring for the org's first data engineer and prior analyst roles
- Led the data org through the CDO transition (Dec 2024 – Dec 2025): set department roadmap, hiring, vendor strategy, and budget, reporting directly to the CTO
- Oversaw a 30+ app R Shiny suite informing decisions across housing, public safety, maternal health, benefits delivery, and criminal justice
- Evaluated and selected the enterprise tooling stack: Databricks (chosen over Snowflake / dbt-Cloud after a capacity assessment), Claude Enterprise org-wide, vendor data feeds (MySidewalk, DataAxle)
- Built project-management infrastructure in Notion now adopted across multiple CPAL departments

Manager, Data

May 2022 – May 2023

- Led development of R Shiny applications, shifting the organization toward interactive data products
- Contributed to northtexasevictions.org, a public-facing eviction data transparency tool
- Mentored analytics interns; one was subsequently hired as a full-time analyst
- Established data collection and sharing procedures that became organizational standards

Associate, Data

Jun 2020 – Apr 2022

- Created the initial eviction data pipeline in R, laying the groundwork for the system now serving four counties
- Developed dashboards and reports in R, QGIS, Tableau, and ArcGIS for internal teams and community partners
- Automated routine data processes, establishing repeatable frameworks used across the organization

EARLIER EXPERIENCE

Research Project Assistant, UT Southwestern Medical Center	Dec 2019 – May 2020
Conducted participant interviews and assessments, analyzed data, and produced reports for biomedical research projects.	
Health & Social Policy Intern, Children at Risk	Jun 2019 – Aug 2019
Led policy research on early childhood development and developed policy briefs for senior leadership and state stakeholders.	
Research Coordinator, University of Texas at Dallas	Aug 2016 – Dec 2018
Managed the Developmental Neurolinguistics Lab; recruited, trained, and supervised 10–15 research assistants each semester and 300+ participants.	
Research Assistant, Florida International University	May 2013 – May 2015
Assessed pre-K children's spatial and verbal abilities; trained assistants and recruited participants across Miami-Dade County schools.	

SKILLS

Analysis & Languages	R (tidyverse, sf, Shiny) · SQL · Python · TypeScript
Visualization & Geospatial	R Shiny · Tableau · Highcharts · Mapbox GL · Spatial SQL · QGIS · ArcGIS
Data Platform	Databricks (Lakehouse + Unity Catalog) · PostgreSQL / Neon · DuckDB · Polars · PostGIS · CKAN
AI Workflows	Claude Code (custom skills & agents) · Anthropic API · Google Cloud Vision (OCR)
Orchestration & Infra	Terraform · GitHub Actions · Docker · AWS · Vercel · Prefect · Structured logging
Domains	Housing & Eviction · Public Safety · Maternal Health · Benefits Delivery · Community Development

EDUCATION

Master of Public Policy, University of Texas at Dallas	2021
B.A., Psychology & Anthropology, Florida International University	2015

SELECTED PROJECTS

- **Dallas County Eviction Data.** Daily eviction-filing feed reaching 12+ legal-aid and outreach partners; ~48,000 Dallas filings a year turned into tenant outreach.
- **DigiLab (digilab.cards).** Community-sourced tournament data platform for the global Digimon TCG scene; 5,000+ tournaments logged in six months, with regional meta analysis players use to prep.
- **Parcel Block Walking Tool.** Field-outreach tool flagging homes likely missing a homestead exemption; ~20 active field-team users across outreach partners.
- **North Texas Evictions.** Public-facing eviction data transparency dashboard for Dallas County.

SELECTED MEDIA

- **The Lab Report** — Data visualizations, Dallas homeless-enforcement and patrol-staffing analyses (2026)
- **D Magazine** — “The Lawyer Who Landlords Don’t Want to See in Court” (2024)
- **KERA News** — “Eviction less likely for Dallas County tenants who get a lawyer” (2024)